

Terror bombing and MW2

Terror suspect Anders Breivik, who allegedly killed 93 people in the Norway bombing claims to have trained with Modern Warfare 2

3DS sales on hold

Online retailer Amazon has suspended the sales of Nintendo 3DS due to an unknown issue with the flip-screen

GPU, such as GTX560M or at least a GTX460M.

Considering its upmarket looks and the sheer size and presence that the GX780R exudes, its performance was a bit of a let down – the major culprit being the GPU. The 3D Mark 11 GPU score of 1157 is lower than its cheaper sibling, the GX660 and this is a trend that continues throughout the gaming tests with *S.T.A.L.K.E.R Call Of Pripyat* giving a mere 24.8 fps at maximum settings (the GX660



MSI GX780R

scores 59.3 fps at the same settings). *Far Cry 2* is an older game, and not as GPU-intensive. Rather it stresses the CPU and owing to this, the quad core on the GX780R pushes it ahead of the GX660. A Unigine Heaven 2.5 score of 491 is quite low and the GX780R will struggle to play the latest games at higher resolutions. While the GX660 supports a maximum resolution of 1366x768 pixels, the GX780R goes up to 1920x1080 pixels, and here its weaker GPU is even more exposed.

At a price tag of ₹1,19,999, the MSI GX780R is certainly not for the uber gamer. For a notebook with such a high native screen resolution, the GPU should definitely have been better and we'd gladly sacrifice a little build quality to get it.

MSI GT680R: ₹1,19,999

One look at the GT680R and it's obvious that the GX660 is a stable mate – they're identical looking. That's aside from the fact that the GT680R lacks an express card slot that's present on the GX660. However, upon investigating, we found that there are differences in the quality of the construction of both notebooks and this seems to be a function of price. For example, the lid on the GT680R seems to have less flex and the keypad is a bit better built.

The keypad feels springier compared to the GX660 and the keys themselves are nicer to press. Although for such a high-end notebook we have to mention the lack of a backlit keypad – something that gamers and

common users alike will find useful.

The GT680R is a high-end gaming machine in MSI's books, and its configuration certainly tries to live up to this. A quad core, Core i7 2630QM, 8 GB of DDR3 1333 MHz RAM and an NVIDIA GeForce GTX460M make it a reasonably potent machine on paper. Once again, we were hoping for a faster graphics solution but that was not to be. Still, the GTX460M is a good part, with 192 stream processors although it's a far cry from its desktop equivalent that has 336 stream processors.

While testing, one thing stood

GAMING NOTEBOOK OR DESKTOP?

For most readers, gaming means a bit of *Far Cry* at a resolution of 1024x768 pixels with medium settings, so a ₹45,000 laptop is our de facto recommendation. However, if you're serious about gaming, want to play *Metro 2033*, *Call Of Duty: Black Ops* or *Crysis 2* at a resolution say 1600x900 or above, and with DX11, a notebook won't cut it. Unless you can afford to buy a really high-end Alienware from the US, consisting of two GTX580M graphics cards in SLI, a desktop is a better bet. For two reasons, a desktop with a similar configuration will probably cost less than half than a netbook. Secondly, notebook components are seriously cut down versions of their desktop cousins. Take an NVIDIA GTX 460 for example. While this card's GPU typically runs at 775 MHz, the GPU on the GTX460M (laptop equivalent) runs at a much lower 550 MHz. Where the desktop version has 336 stream processors, the portable version only has 192. Why does this happen? Notebooks have drastically less space in which to fit components, and heat is a perennial issue. It's also costlier to shrink these components, so a GTX460M will be costlier to manufacture than a GTX460.

It may be shocking that we're advocating a desktop in the midst of a laptop comparison, but a desktop will always be much better performer. That being said, there are many reasons to buy a notebook over a desktop – portability, space constraints, a quick carry for the next LAN party, style and the show-off factor. If you need one, get one, but do match your GPU with the games you play.

out – the GT680R is a very fast 1TB drive with transfer rates of 78.03 MBps and 66.69 MBps, respectively in sequential and non-sequential tests. And it's pretty good for gamers too, with scores of 54.8 fps in *S.T.A.L.K.E.R Call Of Pripyat* at maximum settings, and 36.4 fps at full HD 1080p with maximum settings. This is quite playable, and if you're willing to sacrifice a bit of eye candy, you'll be rewarded with faster frame rates too. Even in 3D Mark 11, the GT680R scores a respectable 1595 points.

All this performance

does come at a price though – at ₹1,19,999 the GT680R is expensive and people spending this much will get turned off by its rather mediocre looks and finish. If you can stand the look though, the GT680R is a decent choice for playing most of the recent games and all older games and edges out the G74SX for a Best Buy award.

ASUS G74SX: ₹1,24,990

ASUS has just launched its ROG series of gaming notebooks in India, and the G74SX is its top dog. This is a monster of a notebook that even dwarfs the massive Alienware M17x, and is built like a tank. Seriously, if you were ever to be the victim of an attempted mugging with the G74SX in your possession you could simply use it as a weapon and bludgeon your opponent senseless. The ASUS moniker and ROG logo are boldly embossed on it, but there's no fancy backlighting like on the Alienware notebooks. The notebook is massively thick towards



MSI GT680R